

Essential Git Commands For Junior Developers

Git is your digital safety net and time machine while writing software. Mastering these basic commands ensures you can collaborate smoothly without losing your hard work.

What you'll learn:

- 1 Downloading Code with Git Clone
- 2 Checking Your Work with Git Status
- 3 Saving Progress with Add and Commit
- 4 Sharing and Syncing with Push and Pull

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Downloading Code with Git Clone

When you join a new project, you need the codebase on your local machine. This command downloads the entire project history and sets up a connection to GitHub automatically. Open your terminal, navigate to your workspace folder, and paste the clone command. Always make sure you are in the right folder before running it so your project files stay organized.

```
$git clone https://github.com/mramanrajsingh/sample-project.git
```

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Checking Your Work with Git Status

Think of this command as checking your rearview mirror before making a turn. It tells you which files are modified, which are staged, and which are untracked. You will run this command dozens of times a day to verify your current workspace state. If you ever feel lost about what you changed, this is your first stop.

```
$git status
```

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Saving Progress with Add and Commit

Git does not save your files automatically like Google Docs; you have to tell it when to take a snapshot. First, use `git add` to select the files you want to save. Next, use `git commit` with a clear message describing what you did. Good commit messages make it much easier for your team to understand your changes later.

```
$git add .  
git commit -m "add user profile picture upload feature"
```

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Sharing and Syncing with Push and Pull

Software development is a team sport, meaning you constantly need to share your code. Use git push to upload your local commits to GitHub for your team to review. Use git pull to download any new code your teammates have uploaded while you were working. Running pull before you push prevents annoying merge conflicts.

```
$git pull origin main  
git push origin main
```


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Key Takeaways

- + Always run git status before staging files
- + Write short and clear commit messages
- + Pull the latest changes before starting your work day
- + Use feature branches instead of coding directly on main
- + Keep your commits small and focused on one task

Watch Out For

- ! Forgetting to pull before pushing and getting merge conflicts
- ! Using git push --force and accidentally overwriting teammate code
- ! Writing useless commit messages like 'fixed stuff'
- ! Committing large password or secret key files by mistake

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